In IPL, there are more heartbreaks than heart-makes: Justin Langer

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EVERY home had that one cricket loyalist glued to the TV, certain that once Justin Langer and Matthew Hayden took guard, Australia was already winning. Teens traded player cards like currency, and Perth-born opener Justin's was the rarest treasure. These memories came alive as he walked in to launch NiviCap, a firm empowering Indian students to pursue academics in Australia, in a sharply-tailored suit, with an easy smile on his face and that familiar twinkle in his eyes.

Over decades of cricket, Justin has seen fierce rivalries and learned the delicate balance between competition and camaraderie. Talking about India-Australia dynamics, he says, "There's great rivalry and it's fierce; that's how sports should be. But when we walk off the field, everyone is friends. It's like having a sibling. You compete hard, but you still love each other."

As head coach of the Lucknow Super Giants (LSG), he brings the same ethos to the Indian Premier League (IPL). "One of the biggest lessons I've learned is that there are often more heartbreaks than heart-makes. Even this week, I've had to tell a few players that they've been released, and that's really tough. But I'm certain they'll go on to play for other franchises," he shares. Choices, like the recent inclusion of Mohammed Shami and Arjun Tendulkar, were guided by vision and work ethic, as he says, "We have a strong batting unit, so we wanted to be strategic about strengthening our battery of fast bowlers, and we hope to continue building on that approach in the auction too."

Coaching, for Justin, has always been about principles, with everything beginning with a clear vision. "You've got to know where you're going. There's so much noise in the world today, but when you bowl or face a cricket ball, nothing should be in your mind except that ball. When you can trust the right people, prepare well and concentrate on what you can control, that's mental toughness," he adds.

Empathy and care guide Justin's leadership, and he treats his players like a close-knit family, fostering trust and a strong team spirit, as he asserts, "I've never met a champion in any sport or business who is successful without a great work ethic." Setbacks, he insists, shape character. "The first time I was dropped from the Australian cricket team, it felt like the world had imploded. But looking back, that period taught me so much. In cricket, you have more bad days than good days. That's where you learn resilience," he says.

He takes pride in the legacy he left as Australia's coach, particularly after the dark days of Sandpaper Gate (the 2018 ball-tampering scandal). "When I look at the team now, I see great sportsmen and great people. That's the legacy I'd like to leave, helping develop both."

Justin also reflects on cricket's broader connections, especially the IPL's impact, as he calls it unbelievable. "It's wonderful... the number of people who support the game and play it. Honestly, when we write our gratitude diaries, we should be thanking India for what they have done for cricket," he says.

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As a father of four daughters, a coach and a mentor, Justin sees guiding young people as an essential part of his identity. "I care about seeing young people follow their dreams. It was scary to leave behind my family and friends at the age of 16 when I left Perth for England to play cricket. Having my parents' support made all the difference. That trip was the moment I realised I wanted to play professionally and the rest is history," he says.



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